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Bobby Watson

Bobby Watson is one of the most well known alto saxophonists of his generation. He was born in Lawrence, Kansas in 1953 and received degrees in theory and composition from the University of Miami. His move to New York was rewarded by becoming a member of Art Blakey's Jazz Messengers. Bobby acted as the group's musical director, and composed and recorded some of the band's memorable tunes. In the 80s he worked with Sam Rivers, Ricky Ford and George Coleman and became a major player in the hard bop movement. His current group, Urban Renewal, tours frequently in the States and abroad and performed at Hamilton College in January of 1996.

Bobby was interviewed at Hamilton College by Michael Woods on January 19, 1996.

MW: We are filming today for Hamilton College and we're developing a Jazz Archive. We are blessed to have with us Bobby Watson, an incredible saxophone artist, who is going to perform for us tonight. Bobby, tell us a little bit about how you got started playing the sax. How old were you?

BW: Well I started in music when I was ten years old. My father, he made a living flying airplanes and worked for the FAA. In fact he was one of the first blacks to become an inspector, the ones that go in and get the black box when a plane crashes in the country. But the way he worked his way through grammar school, he tuned pianos and repaired instruments, and he played saxophone. He played the tenor. So I heard him playing at night, when he wanted to unwind a little bit, and although he never pursued it as a profession, there was always music in the house and always a piano, sometimes two pianos if he was working on them. And I knew from a young age I wanted to play music and so the first chance I got I was bugging my parents and when the time came to start public school, then they got me a clarinet. In fact the year before I started piano, when I was in fourth grade. And so that was my first instrument I started on. And I took piano lessons all through high school, as well as being in the school band on clarinet. And when I got to be about in tenth grade, ninth grade, I started messing with the saxophone like my father, and so I started playing a tenor. And maybe about my junior year, about 1970, I started playing alto. And that was more close to my voice. I have a high voice, and it just seemed natural from the clarinet. The keys were closer, and it felt big in the hand and I felt more natural with that one, so I gravitated toward alto. And my first experience playing in public was in the church. I played piano in church and then when I started playing clarinet I remember my first performance was "Battle Hymn of the Republic." I

remember that. And "Amen, Amen" as it was over. And so I've always been connected to playing in the church mainly.

MW: I want to ask you something about that. Two things. You know a lot of African-American artists have a church background. Many of them started in church, no matter what they do later. But how did it feel, especially like when there were older people in the church that say, "Yeah I like that," and they say, "Amen," you know?

BW: Well it felt good they were giving you encouragement you know, and that's your first feeling of playing and getting gratification back. And that's really what the whole thing I think about music, when you're playing and the audience lets you know. And I remember, because before, years before I had started to have enough nerve to stand up in front, I seen the older people would get up and sing a A and B selection. And then they would like move you. Sometimes they would sing and they would really sing good. And then they would just move the whole congregation. So that would be something, to watch my father, he would play in the church. And when he would play the saxophone and get into it, playing "Precious Lord" or something, and everybody would go, "Um hum, um hum, yes, go ahead and say it, Watson, go ahead and say it." So it was like you knew that they were listening and they were with you. And I think that must have been part of the intoxication too.

MW: Let me ask you one other thing, is you know we talked to a lot of jazz artists and in their own ways, in their own words they, many of them confirm that there is a type of spirituality in this music. In other words the music is more than just the technical ability to move fast over the keys.

BW: Yeah. It's, I believe that it's a language and that the notes and all the things you learn, the exercises, the calisthenics, over the years are basically just the framework of the language, and once you learn how to manipulate that, like the alphabet and sentence structure, and that's comparable in music as the different modes and all the intervals, which are the building blocks of the music, that's what you're able to pick. You know if you do a rising line, that brings a certain feeling or if you drop your line that gives a certain feeling of melancholy. So I believe that it's a language and I know that Herb Jeffries, I had a chance to work with him when I was working with Panama Francis up in the Rainbow Room. And Herb Jeffries came in for a month from Paris. And he told me a lot of stories because he knew Sidney Bechet. So I figured I'd get pretty close-hand information about the history of the music. And he says that during the jam sessions, Sidney Bechet would be playing and he would say, "Now I'm going to call my dog." And he'd play something, I don't know what it was, a sound, and his dog would come in. And I think it relates to when they took the drums away when we arrived in America, that the whole language of the drums, because you know the drums were used for

communication. So I believe that that sublimated into the instruments and so this communication is sort of the underlying thing about the instruments. Because I know I feel there is something that you know when I'm blowing, I get something off your chest, you know when you're playing, that you really can't put into words. But when you're playing an instrument, after you're done you feel satisfied like if you said something you needed to say that day you know? And I know depending on how I feel, my instrument lets me know what kind of day it's going to be. That's for sure. I mean that's my barometer. When I pick that horn up I know if it's going to be a good day or how well I'm feeling or how rested I am or how tired I am. And I think that's the thing that I try to get over to the students you know, is you learn this, now what do you want to say? What do you want to play? See the whole fun thing about jazz was you know you're not supposed to do what's there. I'm going to read the part but after I got the part I'm going to start adding notes and changing it, and I'm going to take it the way I hear it. You know? And so it's like man, you know, why do you want to play something the same way this guy did it? Simple things like this you know. Or I used to sit in front of the T.V. and I would memorize or play along with the theme songs on T.V. Just use your ear. Things like this are certain things that guide you in this music.

MW: Tell us about you know, some of the things you're saying are fabulous because they're insights of personal experience that you have as to the sound. But you've also studied composition and theory haven't you? Tell us about your time of study.

BW: Oh, I studied with a man, his name was Clifton Williams. And he is very big in the concert band field. He has several things published. We played them when I was in high school. So when I got a chance to study with him, that's one of the reasons I went to the University of Miami, was to study with Clifton Williams. And he taught me as a composer, not as a jazz composer. He said, "I want you to be a good composer, so that way, whatever you want to do, whether it be jazz or classical, you will at least have the craft." And one of the first tests he gave us was he wrote a bunch of emotions, a list, he made — love, hate, boredom, inebriation — a different list of emotions. And anger, fright/fear. And you had to write eight bars, no harmony just the melody. And he said that you would be able to get that across on the piano. He would sit there with his back to the wall and you would pick one. He had a list. And you would just play and he had to guess what it was. And what you had at your disposal was like the rhythmic, how fast it is; the attack; the dynamics; the direction of notes; and that was his test to see if you had a gift for composition. And if you got at least half, you were in the ballpark. That was his method, you know? And that was very exciting for me and I've never forgot that and I use that because you know if you're going to do love say, you want to have a note going down, or pride, that was one of them [scats staccato]. So you had to think what is going

to give pride. Or boredom is like [scats]. Like that you know? And so you'd have to guess, and depending on the value of the notes and how hard you hit the notes, you find that those are your tools in composition. That you manipulate the notes and then by doing that you manipulate people's emotions. And it's a very exciting thing. So that's how I write now. Sometimes the chords come first, but most of the time I go for the melody. And I keep a little journal if I hear something I'll write it down and then I'll get back to it later. You may change a note here or there, but basically you know, if something comes to you, you write that down. You used to say like your Divine Inspiration — Divine Inspiration doesn't come that often. And usually when it does it comes in four bars. Very rarely do you hear a song and it's complete. I must have written a few songs that way, it just comes so fast you can't hardly get it down on paper, the whole song. I can probably count that on one hand. But most of my songs, you know you have to toil over them, and I get maybe four bars of Divine Inspiration. And with the craft you stretch that into a whole song.

MW: So four bars of inspiration and the rest of the tune of perspiration.

BW: That's right. There's only one person wrote in pen and that was Mozart. Everybody else uses pencil you know? So I have to realize that. You know Beethoven, he used a pencil. So I say hey, you know you write it, you throw it away, and you have to, it's perspiring.

MW: You know that's fabulous that you have these combination of skills. Am I correct in saying that many saxophone players say that the clarinet is the more difficult instrument? And if you start on that, switching to clarinet is easier?

BW: Saxophone you mean. Starting on clarinet you mean and going to saxophone is easier? Yes it is. The only adjustment you have to make is your embouchure, because the clarinet is more of a tight smile and the saxophone is more of a frown. That took me a few years to make that. But most definitely, because with the clarinet, your fingers are the pads. So you have to be really exact. And like I say if you push the octave key, it's not an octave key, it goes up a twelfth. So you have a whole different set of fingerings once you push that button. With the saxophone, you just push it and it goes up an octave, so it's a lot easier.

MW: Tell us about playing with one of the absolute masters of jazz, an institution within himself. Tell us about Art Blakey.

BW: Yeah, he was, when I was with him first of all, I was with him four and a half years and so I just hung out with him. I didn't try to tell him nothing. You know I see a lot of young kids, they don't know how to keep their mouth shut, you know? That's the biggest thing you've got to learn how to do is keep your ears open and your mouth shut. You know? Ears open, mouth shut. And that's what I did with Art. And he appreciated that. If Art asked me my opinion on something, I would give it. He'd say "what do you think about

this, Bobby?" Well I think this— But I never try to tell him anything of my own personal experiences, because I figured what can I tell him? He's played with Bird and everybody, and so there was nothing that I was going to tell him, my experiences aren't relevant to this man. And if he wants to know — the only thing that's relevant to this man is my performance on the bandstand and for me trying to be the best Jazz Messenger I can be and to make sure that he's happy. So I took it as an apprenticeship for four years, at least to lay that groundwork. So but with that in mind, I hung out with him anywhere. After the gig I went home with him to his room, I called him first thing in the morning to check in and where you going? You going to eat? I'm going with you. So for four and a half years I was under his armpit. The other guys, you know, they split after the gig. I went with him. Because the thing about Art that would scare a lot of people is that you know that if he loved you, and the more he got to know you, at one point he's going to bust you. He could read you. He'd look at you and he can read you. He knew your weaknesses and your strengths, on the instrument and in your personality. And being around him, you knew that. I don't know, it was just a feeling that you knew he was looking right through you. And so that's scary. Because no one wants to get criticized. But if you're going to, one of the prices you have to pay to hang out with a man like this, is you're going to get criticized. At some point he's going to tell you what he really thinks about you. And what he really thinks about your playing. And you know it. And so a lot of guys would get away. But I stayed up there to the hammer. And every so often he'd tell me "Bob, you're not swinging" but he wouldn't say it like that. "Bobby, you're not swinging. You sound like you're playing out of an exercise book." And you know that's pretty shocking, you know? But he's telling the truth. And you'd have to think about it. Or he would say "you're overblowing your horn—you're out of tune—you're blowing too hard, just relax." And those are the things that helped me. Because I took it to heart and I was at the age where I was like open to that. And I didn't have a block-up in my mind, so he could work with me, like putty in his hands. But at the same time you have to submit yourself to that. So it's a sense of submission is where you gain your strength. Because if a man loves you and you submit to him, you only got to do it one time. Because you will learn, and then you've got that. And then the next time, you'll have to submit to something else, but if you do that long enough, you'll cover everything. And you see people who have a lot of resistance in their heart to criticism. And you know that they're never going to learn and get past a certain point because all the great ones, when you're being around a person like Art, you realize that's how they talk to each other. They were brutally honest. Brutally honest. And they always told the truth, the way they saw it. And you had to think about it. Because they really don't want to say nothing to you. And the only reason they

would say something to you is that they loved you. If they didn't love you they'd say, "Yeah baby, you sound good." They tell you what you want to hear.

MW: But they just let you go on.

BW: They let you go on because they know that's what you want to hear. You couldn't take the truth. If I say well you're really kind of repeating yourself. They'd say, "That Art Blakey's a jerk." You know? And they know that. So they can see the ones that really want to learn, and at first I used to cry, I'd say, "Man, why are you talking to me like this?" He'd say "man if I didn't love you, I wouldn't say nothing to you." So I thought about that, and I would wait for those. And I would get worried when he'd stop talking to me, because he must be mad, you know, I wouldn't want that. I wanted to keep that door open. And man, we hung out and had a great time. He's like a child, man. He's like Peter Pan. He never grew up, just got older. The only way he knew how old he was was when he looked in the mirror. You know, we woke up to him, he was still a young man, and he ran into the ground man. We'd be traveling sometimes 14 hours a day. And I'd look at him and he looked like he was half dead. And he is twice our age. And I go man, I know when we get to the gig he's probably going to cancel. Because I was dead, I didn't feel like playing no saxophone. I never worked this hard in my life. So I just couldn't imagine making any music after the day we've had. Man, shoot, he'd get up there, and we'd play for two hours straight. That's when he played the hardest. You know? And he would drive us. We couldn't keep up with him. And he had a love. And he'd get up on that stage and we might have been hanging out all day, but when he got up on that stage he could just look and he didn't see nobody. He'd just be into them drums. And you'd just feel this joy that he was getting from him playing the drums, and he wasn't depending on nobody else in the band to make him happy. Like either you come along with me or get left behind. And you're thinking about how tired you are — I have an ache — my lip hurts — my reed. And you look over here and this man's going [scats] with a big smile on his face. And I'm going, what's wrong with me? I better get with it. Because it was very selfish, you know? He got up there and it was like, I thought we were supposed to be tired, but he's just like burning over there, because that's what brings him his joy. The bandstand was a sanctuary for him. It was like he said if you have an argument all day, you leave all your arguments and disagreements at the edge of the bandstand. Because when you step on that bandstand, that's an altar. And it's a very sacred place and it's our sanctuary. So we did. We had sometimes mean days. You know we were mad at him and everything, but when we got up there, he'd look us right in the eye and smile and say blow, baby, blow. And you know you couldn't avoid eye contact, because he would know it. Because on that bandstand, you've got to look each other in the eye. You've got

to look every man in the eye and say, "I got your back baby. I got you man, I got you, don't worry baby, I got you." And it's like that you know?

MW: Teamwork.

BW. Teamwork. And when you got off the stage, go your separate ways. Later for him. But when you're on that stage, you've got to be able to look each other in the eye.

MW: Got to be able to do it.

BW: And that's when you know, and you're very sensitive to that when a guy gets on the stage and you can tell when he's still carrying something in their heart for the day. So I became very sensitive of that and Art taught me the value of that, you know, because there's a direct lineage from Bird, and I knew I was hearing it from direct lineage. And I took everything he said to heart.

MW: Oh, that's awesome. That's wonderful. Let me ask you something else about this teamwork. You know jazz is a music where every player improvises, not just the player that's playing the solo. There's levels of improvisation going on in accompaniment. And if it doesn't work as a team it doesn't work.

BW: Absolutely.

MW: Talk to us about that.

BW: Well it's like when they give you a piece of music say for instance. The composer may have put certain rhythms on there or certain voicings. Or like when I pass out bass parts, I say please don't play that, this is just an idea. I am not a bass player, so please don't play what I wrote, but this will just give you a general feel, now I want you to take it and do your thing with it. And the drums, same with the drums. You know you've got some guys who say, "I want you to play this" [scats]. I say man, please, you've got a great drummer here, what are you trying to tell him? It's because when I first got with Art, we did "Gypsy Folk Tales" and I had been in the band two weeks and suddenly we were making a record. I had a couple of songs, because my composition teacher says, "You're probably going to get work as a player before you will as a composer, so whatever ensemble you're in, try to have something ready. Because there might be an extra ten minutes at the end of a rehearsal so you can say 'excuse me, would you mind reading this down?'" So I was ready. So when he says — we had just recorded a couple of Walter Davis tunes and he looked over at me, "Who got something?" And he knew I did. So I pulled out two tunes you know? It was "Time Will Tell" and "Heart Man." And I pulled them out and I passed out the parts and I had a drum part, I was just out of college and it was all neat, and I said, "Here, Art, here's your part and it's kind of an Elvinish type feel and I want this kind of thing over here, broken time." And he's going, "Uh huh, uh huh, uh huh, okay." And he threw it on the floor man. That was my first lesson, man. He goes, "Run it down." So he listened to it about three or four times, and once he had it down he

goes, “Let me try it.” And he put this whole other beat on it and took it somewhere else. And my eyes, I said okay, the little light bulb went off, you know? How stupid I am trying to tell Art Blakey to play it kind of Elvinish. You know I mean he’s an institution of himself, Elvin, and so is Art. And you know if you’ve got Art, you take Art, you don’t want — you want Elvin [Jones], you go get Elvin.

MW: That’s like telling Ali to box like Frasier.

BW: Yeah. You want me, you got me. And so I never wrote drum parts out again, and I still don’t to this day. I may give a trumpet part. And so that’s why this improvisation you’re saying begins immediately when you have artists that are in that spirit of creating so that when they’re comping, they’re actually playing little counter melodies and there’s this voice leading and all the chords, and if you just take away all the chords and just listen to what’s on top, you should hear the little counter melodies flowing behind you and in the bass, if you really just isolate the bass you’ll hear how he’s composing on his bass lines. His melodies that he’s walking, that’s how they’re able to keep walking all them bars, they’re improvising. They’re soloing on the bass. And so it’s like everything is in motion. If you’ve got guys that are playing the stuff over and over the way you wrote it, that’s not jazz. The hardest thing is to get people to realize that you’re improvising from the word go. You know you’ve picked the voicings. You picked the rhythm. When you want to hear the drums, you guys hook up on something behind the soloist to push him on. And that’s the whole thing about it. It’s a team ball. You pass. And when you hear the guy go over to the cymbal, you can almost hear it coming. You know he’ll do a roll and it’s like when you turn the corner, you know you put the signal light on about 50 feet before. So you hear the signal light come on, and you hear him slow down to make the curve. So you hear these things in the music. So you as a soloist you’re going, okay, they’re going to curve and you go right with them. And they see the same thing. When they see my shoulder start going like this and I start stomping my foot, they go oh there he goes. And they start feeding me little stuff you know? And we all just move out together. It’s the hardest thing that Art taught me, he said, “When you start to blow, man, you’ve got to trust the guys around you and you all move out together.” And we build, you know, just like that.

MW: Oh, that’s wonderful. Tell us, get us inside of one of your original compositions. What goes through your mind when you write a tune and what parameters do you exploit to try to capture the voice of Bobby Watson in a jazz composition?

BW: Well capturing my voice is really not too hard, because as I discovered on the saxophone, as much as I try to sound like Cannonball and Bird, I sound like Bob. So the thing is to accept who you are. That’s the hardest thing. And once you accept who you are, then it’s really easy because I work with Sam Rivers, and he’s avante garde. And he’s in his 60s

but as he reminds me, when he played bebop, that was avante garde. So he's always been avante garde. And we were on a train one time over in Europe and we were with this group of tenor saxophones called the Winds of Manhattan. And he said let me show you something. Because I was watching and he'd be writing without no piano. And sometimes he'd cut this page and put it over here, and he'd just be writing, without a score. And he says, I said, "How do you do that?" And he says, "Here, take a bit of paper. Write your line." I wrote one line. And, "Write another line, anything you want." He says, and I wrote about five lines and he says, "Now if you hand this out, you pick the instruments and give it to him, it's going to sound like Bobby Watson. No matter what you do it's going to sound like you because you are the creator. And so the creator, there is no mistakes. So whatever you do, you can't escape who you are and through the repetition you start to see." So I don't really make any efforts to do it, it's just that I can't escape myself as much as I would like to. Much as I would like to write some stuff like Duke Ellington or other great arrangers or composers. There are people that do that and I admire them. And what they've done is lifted off the voicings of Duke. And then when they write it sounds like Duke and it puts them on a certain level, but that's not them. So for me, like when I do a big band chart, I don't worry about it. I just write it and I fill in the blanks and I hook it up and then I play it. And then there you go, it's me. And I'm very happy with myself. And I don't really worry about that you know. Again, though that was going back to Art. You know I'm very lucky. Because the things I'm saying now, they're not all my ideas. I'm a dummy. I'm one of the dumbest guys I know. I just had great teachers. I've been very lucky to have these people just come through my life and take an interest in me, and say come over here man, let me show you something. You know? And I've always been like "okay." You know because I figure like this, if you really want to help me, then I'm going to get something out of it. And he's been trying to show me how much he knows, I'm going to learn that too. I'm going to say okay, he's just trying to look big in front of me. And I'll listen to him one time. But that way, the next time he comes around, I don't have to listen to him no more. So again, when you submit yourself to who you are and you submit yourself to input, you find yourself much quicker, because you can't escape who you are. So your weaknesses become your strengths actually you know? You just exploit that too.

MW: I want to say one other thing is your rhythm section players did a marvelous little workshop with our students this afternoon, and they did something, I want you to make a little comment on this. They were playing and I mean we knew our kids couldn't keep up with that. But I would make your rhythm section play then I would make one of our students take a solo. And some would say, "No, no, no, no." And I would say, "Jump in

there, get in there." And so and then the guitar player said, "The whole idea is to jump in over your head, because that's how you learn." Tell us about that.

BW: Well we always said you have to hang with that fast company and you're right, you know, you get in with players that are better than you, they'll make you play stuff you didn't know you could play. And just because by contrast players that are not so good can bring your level down. And the thing I learned from doing a lot of clinics and playing with a lot of high school players, is my level definitely does drop. But it's okay, because I've learned how to play on different levels and still be happy. And that's a thing you learn, not to let them bring you down, because you still have to keep a level of excellence. That's what Art said. Some days you're here, some days you're here, some days you're here. But never go below here. And that's what you have to learn to keep you own level straight. But I learned that from playing with players who are better than me and who consistently, night after night after night, and it's like the kids in basketball. You may be hurting all the time. I mean even guys that never miss a game, they hurt. They play in pain. Their knees hurt and they get calluses on their fingers from handling that ball so much. And people who bowl man, they have to tape their fingers. You're going to pay a price, you pay a price for having yourself in contact with something that's unnatural with the floor or whatever. You're pounding up and down that hardwood floor, it's going to do something to you knees you know? Because that's not really what it was made for. But the human body, it's something how we adapt to things that are challenges in front of us. You know, to play a horn or play a bass and you develop calluses, because that's a reaction to pain. Your body goes whoops, send a bunch of cells over there, you know, and you build up chops and then it looks natural but it's really unnatural. And that's why when people pick up an instrument at first and they're going man this is difficult. Well that's because you have all these kind of hidden muscles and everything, that these people can't see. You have Charles Atlas here and here, or you might be Charles Atlas here you know, where you don't actually look physically strong but you know, where it counts, you're like Charles Atlas you know? And I don't know if I've digressed or what, the point I was trying to make is that this deep company, seeing other guys play through pain, play through fatigue, and then when it's such a thrill you hear you know you get a piano player who just hits something that just complements you, and you're sort of like, oh wow, and then it just pushes you on out further. And you're absolutely right. You should always jump at the chance to play with people who are better than you. I always try to get the strongest cats around me. You know, and guys that have something that I don't have. Because that keeps me on my toes and keeps me honest. I mean for me to be the best cat in the band would be so boring. I don't think I could make it. I don't know if I could make it one month, you know, just having me be

the top all the time? But it's so nice when Harold, the drummer, or Victor Lewis, or all the guys I've had over the years, when they turn it out man, it just inspires you and takes you to another level you know.

MW: I've got to stick in an aside in here. I love the way Victor plays.

BW: Everybody does.

MW: That's for you, Victor. Oh, he's so great.

BW: Oh, he is. He's the mist to the music.

MW: I'm going to ask you one thing, and I know we've got to get you out of here because you've got to get something to eat and get dressed and maybe detox a little bit. But where is jazz going? Give me some places where it can go, or the possibilities that you see in it.

BW: Well, I think we have to stop categorizing. Like now you know I'm doing this electric thing, and because I grew up doing it. But also I play jazz. And so you're going to hear my things be a little bit more aggressive than what they call that soft jazz. Because we're still up there really trying to mesh and play. But that's not all I do. Like I mentioned earlier, I play in the church so I'd like to do a Gospel record at some point. And here's another thing I see that really has changed the dynamics of the music. People like Lou Donaldson and Barry Harris, they're in our generation, a lot of them just started going to Europe maybe ten years ago for the first time in their life. Meanwhile, I'm 42 right now, I've been to Europe maybe 70, 80 times, and all over the world. And so it used to be in the 40s and the 50s and maybe up in the early 60s when they say you do the circuit. And the circuit was basically the country. You know you did a circuit, you'd go down south, you'd go to Chicago, and that was a circuit that all the jazz guys traveled. Except Dexter and Johnny Griffin, they went to Europe, Don Byas and Coleman Hawkins, all them guys went back to Europe for a time. But basically the main circuit that everyone traveled was in America. So but you reflected off of, and then when you did get a chance to go to Europe, you didn't really concern yourself with the locals as they would say. You'd never really hear the local musicians. They were all coming to hear you, because you had jazz. And you were there because you had something that they couldn't find in Europe. So you tended to be a little arrogant maybe and maybe a little closed-minded about hearing some local musicians. Because I found that there are virtuosos that play their music in every country. And a virtuoso is a virtuoso. And so when you meet someone who has this level of skill, and he's playing Greek songs or Bouzouki players what have you, clarinet players from Romania or something like this, it's really wild stuff. And you have to open your ears to that. And they want to hook up with you because now it's 1996 and all through the 70s, things started happening. Now in Europe they have people who are the new Coleman Hawkins, and they're the grandfathers of European jazz and can play. And now you have young kids over there in Germany and all over, France, whatever, they can

play. They can really play. You can not say that jazz is American anymore. Jazz started in America, particularly by black people. But now it has spread throughout the world and has become a proven formula. And it's transcended all racial, sexual and religious nationalistic lines, that if you submit to the music, you will have success, and be able to get to what you're saying inside. Because now there are young kids from other countries that understand what this music is about. So now, when me and my generations that are coming behind me, when we go to Europe, we have to keep our eyes open because we're not special, as in terms of we're not rare birds, because Hans may come over here and he may blow some stuff that will blow you away. So it ain't about just being American and blowing your horn and you ain't going to have any competition, because you've got guys coming out of the woodwork all over the world. So what I'm trying to say is where the music is going is it's taking on the international stage. And that means that the jazz musician has an obligation to bring all kinds of things into his jazz. So I feel that the jazz musicians that are going to be important in years to come are going to be the ones that give you a variety of colors, a variety of sounds, who are able to do a variety of musics, not just swinging anymore. Because we've got the Latin, the Latino stuff is very strong, the Cubans are coming here now, very strong. So in the past there were good players in the rhythm section that could play good jazz, good bebop, but couldn't give it the Latin thing. And then you started to have jazz guys that were starting to realize that bass players, that hey, you've got to go [scats] and get into that and learn clave, and you started to get this crossover as they call it or fusion as they call it. What do they mean by that? You know what I mean? It's just the world is getting smaller and people are able to travel you know, and travel is cheaper, so you have a thing that all cultures have this level of virtuosity in their culture. So as a jazz musician, and Art used to say as a jazz musician, it's the highest form of our musical instrument, I'm not going to back down from any type of music. Because I'm a jazz man, and I'm supposed to be able to play anything. So it's up to me to get with it. So I feel that this is the mindset for the future, is that you should be able to swing and play the bop, but you also should be able to jump in there with some salsa and jump in there with some funk, play – read your ass off, and play some classical music you know, and play some show tunes, play some dinner music, I do weddings you know? I try to do it all. And that's what you see is the difference between the older guys and the younger guys. The younger guys can play everything. They're into James Brown. It's not just a superficial — oh I'm going to play some funk let's put a back beat on it, like when the older cats maybe try to crossover. And that's only because of a generational thing you know. And you have to keep your eyes on the youth and what's coming behind you and take that and incorporate it. Because when I watch old films of Duke Ellington and you look out in the audience, it's the young

people. But my problem is all these young people that were young in 1959, it's 1995 they're coming to my gigs and wanting me to do 1959. Where are the young people? I want the young people. That's what I learned from Art. You've got to have the young people there. And once you know you're tapped into the young folks, you know you're on the right track. So this is the thing I see for the future of the music is that we have an obligation to sit in and deal with the rap, deal with the DJs, deal with all of that because we have the skill and the science and should have the mindset to take whatever comes.

MW: Listen, this has been absolutely marvelous. What an answer. I want to say this, look straight into the camera and say this, this has been one of the most articulate statements that we've had on where jazz may be going in the future. You heard this from Bobby Watson. That means all you students that are interested in jazz, you really have to be eclectic. Learn to do it all. You just heard it from one of the masters. That's great. Listen, we've got to let you go.

BW: Thank you so much.

MW: Get something to eat and detox. This has been absolutely fabulous. And this ends our interview with Bobby Watson for Hamilton Jazz Archive.